

Types of films

From the simplest short cartoon film to a full-length feature with an all-star cast, films cover every subject. There have been notable films on many topics, but some of the most successful movies have been in areas where film can add an extra dimension, such as the vivid settings of fantasy and space adventures or western movies, the special effects of science-fiction and horror films, or the singing and dancing of American musicals.

Jean-Louis Barrault Arletty



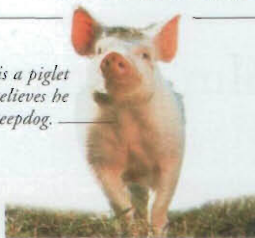
Les Enfants du Paradis, 1944

Romance

Love stories are always popular. The romantic *Les Enfants du Paradis* was made in German-occupied France during World War II; in 1979, French critics voted it the best French film ever made.

Babe is a piglet who believes he is a sheepdog.

Babe, 1995



Comedy

The first films were silent, yet the comic antics of the actors made audiences roar with laughter. Today, comedies range from biting social commentaries to the gentle humour of an animal film such as *Babe*.

Horror

German film makers were the first to realise that audiences like being frightened: directors were making horror movies in Germany by 1913. By the 1930s, horror had caught on in Hollywood, where it has been popular ever since. *Frankenstein* appeared in 1931. More than 100 films have been based on the same theme since.



Boris Karloff as Frankenstein's monster

Special effects

Anything can happen on film, thanks largely to the special effects department, a complex and skilled area of film-making. Effects may range from animals that seem to talk, to horrific dripping wounds, or people appearing to fly through the air.

Make-up

Actors wear make-up to look natural under the bright film lights. Make-up also helps when an actor must look unnatural. A make-up artist can make an actor look much older, or use latex rubber and lining colours to add dreadful wounds. In horror and science-fiction films, make-up is used to turn people into aliens.



Make-up in *Terminator 2*

Eyes, nose, and mouth operated by motors.



Dog, from *The Storyteller*

Movie models

Where it is too costly, dangerous, or impossible to use the real thing, film-makers may turn to models. Tiny models stand in for massive spacecraft in science-fiction films. A talking animal may be a puppet, or an actor in costume whose remote-controlled mask is operated by a puppeteer. This kind of puppetry is called animatronics.

Computers

Computers can manipulate images to create extraordinary special effects. Programs also allow operators to draw and animate characters on screen. Changes are much easier to make here than in animation which has been hand-drawn frame by frame.

Disney's Toy Story is a computer-generated film.



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Blue screen

To create the illusion that a character is flying, an actor is filmed in front of a blue screen. Wind machines make his clothes flutter, as if air is moving past. An optical printer then combines the sequence with footage shot from a plane, or of a simulated space environment. The printer re-photographs images from each film onto a single frame, to blend the two films seamlessly.



Actor held by wires

Timeline

1895 The Lumière brothers open the first public cinema in Paris, France.

1913 By this date, Hollywood, Calif., is the centre of the US film industry.

Academy Award (Oscar)



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1920s Russian director Sergei Eisenstein (1898–1948) introduces cross-cutting, showing bursts of action one after the other so they seem to happen simultaneously.

1927 The Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences is set up; in 1929, it honours film-makers for the first time.

1927 *The Jazz Singer*, made in the US, is the first full-length film with sound.

1932 The "three-strip" process is introduced by the Technicolor company, and colour films, originally developed much earlier, begin to take off.

Technicolor three-strip camera



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1941 US actor-director Orson Welles (1915–85) releases *Citizen Kane*; it explores new techniques in lighting, dialogue, and the use of camera lenses.

1952 The CinemaScope process introduces wide-screen cinema.

CAMERAS

CARTOONS AND ANIMATION

EDISON, THOMAS

VIDEO



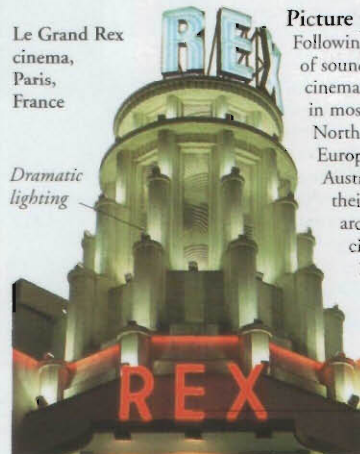
Charlie Chaplin

One of the best-loved comedians of the silent screen, Chaplin (1889–1977) moved to the USA from London as a young man. He appeared in over 60 short films and 11 full-length comedies, including *City Lights* and *Modern Times*. His characterization of a tramp, who keeps a sense of humour despite great hardship, was based on observation of poor people on the London streets.

Going to the movies

By the 1930s, going to the cinema was popular entertainment, but in the 1950s television took over and the film industry declined. Recently, movie-going has grown popular again. Today, multiplex cinemas screen many films at the same time, offering audiences a wide choice of pictures.

Le Grand Rex cinema, Paris, France



Picture palaces

Following the arrival of sound in 1927, cinemas were built in most towns in North America, Europe and Australia. With their impressive architecture, the cinemas of the 1920s and 1930s were often called picture palaces.

Hype and merchandise

The cost of film production means it is vital to make the public eager to see a movie, so that the producers can earn back their investment and make a good profit. Publicists work hard to sell a film before it opens. They inform journalists, and arrange for the actors to appear on television talk shows. This process is known as hype. Selling items related to a movie, such as socks or a mug, is another way of making more money.

Batman merchandise
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Batman logo